

'All we are looking for is how good the athlete is'



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A defining moment of Indian sports in 2023 was the sight of armless archer Sheetal Devi effortlessly winning medals for fun at the Para Asian Games in Hangzhou.

In addition to winning an Arjuna Award, along with countless other adulations, the 17-year-old's heroics have also brought the limelight onto another entity — the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board (SMVDSB), which identified and groomed Sheetal's talents.

In just over seven years since its inception, SMVDSB — with its training facility located in Katra, Jammu — has established itself as a prominent player in Indian sports.

Speaking to *Sportstar* after SMVDSB won the 'Sportstar Sports for Social Good' award in Mumbai, Anshul Garg, its Board's CEO, opened up about the organisation's origin, ideology and ambition.

The Vaishno Devi temple is one of the most popular pilgrim destinations in India. How did your organisation enter the field of sports?

Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board (SMVDSB) is largely dedicated to pilgrimage management. We are one of the most visited pilgrim sites in the country. Over the past seven, or eight years, we have diversified into a lot of other activities. This includes healthcare, education and sports.

Sports is a major part of our social outreach programme. We started in 2016 when Prime Minister Narendra

Modi inaugurated our sports complex. Then we started grooming local talent, focussing on four major disciplines — archery, shooting, judo and athletics.

There was no other platform like this in the entire state. That was the reason we started. Secondly, athletics comes naturally to the people of the mountainous regions. We have been trying to nurture their potential.

We have state-of-the-art equipment, trainers and a residential facility for local students. We are grooming them to excel at the national level. We have been lucky to achieve results at the international level within a short period.

Sheetal Devi's success has now propelled your organisation to national fame. How did SMVDSB wade into para-archery and how has it been to observe Sheetal's growth from such a close range?

We started archery in 2017. We hired two coaches, and we identified local kids. What interested us was that a lot of para-athletes in and around Katra were interested in the discipline.



'Rakesh was the first stepping stone. Sheetal has built on it and now a lot of girls in the region have been inspired by her. We have high hopes for both of them from the Paris Olympics' — Anshul Garg

So, Rakesh Kumar was the first para-archer we groomed. He represented India at the Tokyo Olympics, and this motivated a lot of people to take up the sport in the region. And Sheetal was one of them. She is from a remote village in Jammu and has been with us for the last two years. She trains and resides in our facility.

With the kind of energy that she carries, she is not scared of competition. For a girl of just 17, to perform at the national level itself is a huge deal. But going to the Asian Games, and winning the gold medal, is something worth celebrating.

Community interaction and local support are extremely important for such a residential facility to thrive. How do you feel the community has warmed up to the initiative?

When we started, our coaches and trainers had to go out to the villages to hunt for talent. We had to convince parents to send their kids. Nowadays, the process has reversed. Now, people across Jammu are approaching us, asking if their kids